Offroad & 4x4 Safety Guide

Safety essentials for offroading and 4x4 adventures in Pierce County and the Cascade Mountains

Pierce County sits at the doorstep of some of the best 4x4 terrain in the Pacific Northwest — from forest service roads in the Cascades to historic wagon routes across mountain passes. As the 4x4 SAR unit, offroading is literally what we do. Here's how to enjoy it safely.

Pierce County Offroad Areas

Naches Pass / Naches Trail

Starting from the Enumclaw/Greenwater area, this trail crosses the Cascades entirely on a continuous 4x4 route following the 1853 Longmire wagon train route. A very good beginner trail that terminates at Forest Service Road 1913 on the eastern side. Scenic views, moderate difficulty, and historical significance.

Mowich Lake Road (Highway 165)

A 17-mile gravel road climbing to over 5,000 ft, ending at Mowich Lake in Mt. Rainier National Park. Located 5 miles south of Wilkeson. Not technically offroading, but the road surface and elevation demand 4x4 awareness. Steep grades, loose gravel, no guardrails.

National Forest Roads

The Mt. Baker-Snoqualmie and Gifford Pinchot National Forests surrounding Pierce County have hundreds of miles of forest service roads ranging from well-maintained gravel to unmaintained tracks. Many are gated seasonally. Check the USFS Motor Vehicle Use Maps (MVUMs) for current access.

> **SAR PRO TIP**
> Stay on designated roads and trails. Blazing new trails or driving through meadows gets 4x4 areas shut down permanently. We've seen it happen. Tread lightly and protect access for everyone.

Vehicle Preparation

- ☐ Tires: All-terrain or mud-terrain with adequate tread. Check pressure before the trail (lower for traction, air back up for highway).
- ☐ Recovery gear: Tow strap (NOT a chain), D-ring shackles, recovery boards/MaxTrax, hi-lift jack or bottle jack with base plate.
- ☐ Fluids: Check oil, coolant, brake fluid, power steering, transfer case. Carry extra coolant and oil.
- ☐ Spare tire: Full-size spare, not a donut. Verify the lug wrench fits and the jack works before you leave.
- ☐ Tools: Basic toolkit, tire plug kit, air compressor or CO2 inflator, zip ties, duct tape, JB Weld.
- ☐ Communication: CB radio (channel 4 is common offroad), cell phone + power bank, satellite communicator for remote areas.
- ☐ Fuel: Full tank + extra fuel if available. Know your vehicle's range on rough terrain (significantly less than highway).

Offroad Safety Rules

Trail Etiquette

Uphill traffic has the right of way (it's harder to restart on an incline). Yield to hikers, horses, and mountain bikes. Use a spotter for blind corners and obstacles. Travel in groups of 2+ vehicles when possible.

Water Crossings

Walk the crossing first if you can't see the bottom. Check depth, current, and bottom firmness. Enter slowly (bow wave ahead of your bumper, not over your hood). Know your vehicle's fording depth. After crossing, tap brakes gently to dry them. Never cross moving water above mid-tire depth.

Recovery Safety

Never use a tow ball as a recovery point — they can become lethal projectiles under load. Use rated recovery points (D-ring shackles on frame-mounted mounts). Lay a blanket or heavy jacket over the strap to dampen it if it breaks. Keep bystanders well clear of the strap's path. Winch with steady pressure, never jerking.

SAR PRO TIP

The single most important piece of recovery gear is a buddy. Never offroad alone in remote areas. If you must go solo, tell someone your exact route and carry a satellite communicator. We've responded to solo drivers stuck miles from cell service.

Mechanical Breakdown

If your vehicle breaks down on a remote road: stay with your vehicle (it's easier to find than a person). Deploy visible markers (bright clothing, reflective triangles). If you have cell service, call for help. If not, use your satellite communicator or wait for other trail users. Conserve your phone battery.

Offroad Checklist

- ☐ Trip plan filed with emergency contact (route, vehicle description, return time)
- ☐ Full tank of fuel + extra if going remote
- ☐ Recovery gear: tow strap, shackles, jack, boards
- ☐ Basic tools, tire plug kit, air compressor
- ☐ First aid kit + emergency supplies (blanket, food, water)
- ☐ Communication: cell phone, power bank, CB or satellite communicator
- ☐ Offline maps downloaded (Gaia GPS or onX recommended for forest roads)
- ☐ Check trail/road conditions and seasonal closures before departure
- ☐ Travel with at least one other vehicle when possible

SATELLITE 911 TEXTING

T-Mobile offers satellite 911 texting — FREE for all carriers (emergency 911 only). Full satellite messaging is $10/mo. Most forest service roads have NO cell service. Sign up at t-mobile.com/coverage/satellite-phone-service/911-texting-signup